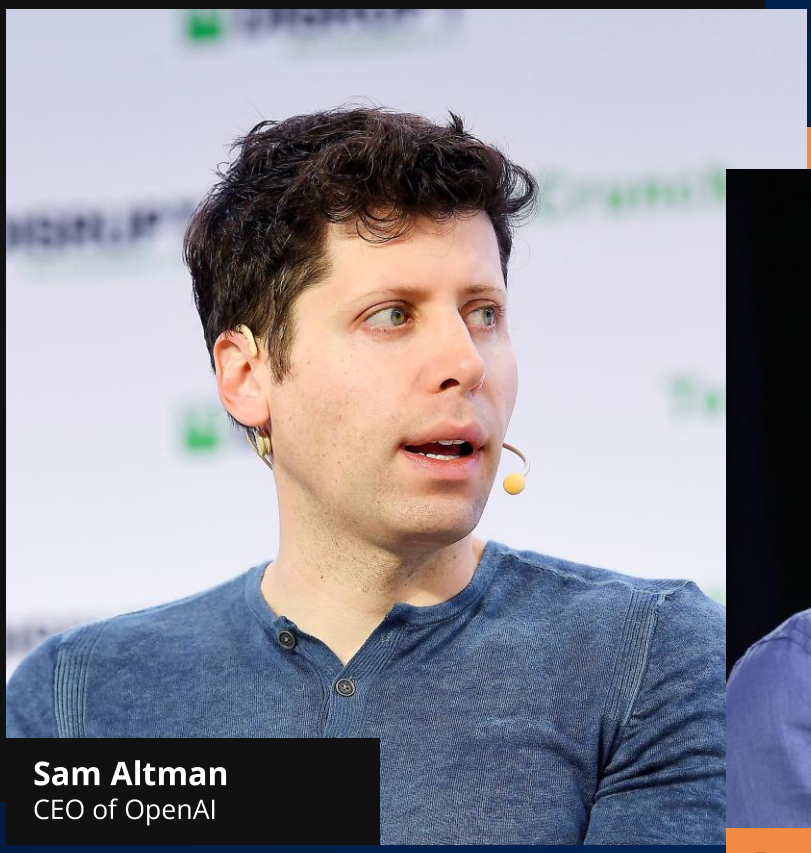
M&A

NOVA SBE MERGERS AND ACQUISITIONS STUDENT CLUB



Sam Altman
CEO of OpenAI



Dario Amodei
CEO of Anthropic

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INSIGHT COVERAGE · Nova SBE Mergers & Acquisitions Student Club

OpenAI and Anthropic: IPO Timing vs. Pricing

IPO's | Research Department · Issue No. 1

Nova School of Business and Economics | 5th of November 2026

The Topic

Insight Coverage | Issue No. 1

OpenAI and Anthropic are re-timing their IPOs. How much of it is about price?

No listing date was ever set, so these are slipping targets, not formal postponements. The Club ask whether price, a closed market or the companies' own choices explain the slippage, and what it means for US IPO supply.

RELEVANCE

Both can wait, but not forever. Anthropic holds $131.7bn of cash and generated $3.9bn of operating cash in H1, yet has signed ~$530bn of multi-year compute commitments (S-1). OpenAI is raising ~$30bn privately. Neither is a forced seller, so timing is a choice.

OpenAI filed a confidential draft S-1 on 8 June; on 19 August its CFO told staff it would list in 2027 "or sooner". On 12 September Sam Altman told Fortune a 2026 IPO would be "ill-advised" given AI safety: "we don't feel pressure". Anthropic filed confidentially on 1 June, its target slid to November, and on 26 October it filed publicly. Neither has a price range or date.

Backdrop. SpaceX priced the largest IPO on record at $135 ($1.77tn) on 11 June and dipped below it intraday on 15 July (Reuters). It shows buyers will not hold any trillion-dollar mark, not what they pay for an AI lab: SpaceX's business, ~4% float and 30% retail share differ.

Price talk eased, in reports. On 15 October Reuters reported some Anthropic investors discussing ~$1.5tn, down from ~$2tn, with its sources pointing to slower growth (Q3 +45% QoQ vs +147% in Q2). OpenAI's round talk has moved within $1.2–1.4tn (FT, Bloomberg, CNBC). These are negotiating positions from unnamed sources, not prices, and not all on the same basis.

Our reading. Price best explains Anthropic's timing. For OpenAI the stated reason is safety, and the evidence cannot yet separate it from price or funding. Pages 2–4 test this.

2026	TIMELINE	SOURCE (DATE)	STATUS
1 Jun	Anthropic submits confidential draft S-1	Anthropic (1 Jun)	*Company*
8 Jun	OpenAI submits confidential draft S-1	OpenAI (8 Jun)	*Company*
25 Jun	OpenAI reportedly leans toward a 2027 IPO	NYT (25 Jun)	*Media*
19 Aug	OpenAI CFO tells staff: public in 2027 "or sooner"	CNBC (19 Aug)	*Media**
12 Sep	Altman: a 2026 IPO would be "ill-advised" given AI safety	Fortune (12 Sep)	*Company*
Mid-Sep	Anthropic's reported target slips to November	WSJ via Forbes (23 Sep)	*Media*
29 Sep	OpenAI seeks ~$30bn at ~$1.4tn	Bloomberg (29 Sep)	*Media*
15 Oct	Some Anthropic investors discuss ~$1.5tn	Reuters (15 Oct)	*Media*
22 Oct	OpenAI round at $1.25tn pre-money	CNBC (22 Oct)	*Media*
26 Oct	Anthropic files public S-1 (ANT, Nasdaq)	SEC EDGAR (26 Oct)	*Filing*

KEY POINTS

Neither issuer has a date or a price; Anthropic has filed publicly, OpenAI confidentially

Reported talk fell for Anthropic (~$2.0tn → ~$1.5tn); OpenAI's has stayed within $1.2–1.4tn

OpenAI's CEO cites safety, not markets. Its own projected cash burn rises to ~$57bn in 2027 (The Information, Feb): private money buys time, not a permanent substitute

AT A GLANCE

TOPIC
Delayed AI mega-IPOs

COMPANIES
OpenAI, Anthropic

SECTOR
Frontier AI

GEOGRAPHY
United States

> *"Anthropic's delay looks like a negotiation over price; OpenAI says safety, not markets, sets its timing. Only the first claim can be tested this year."*

KEY TAKEAWAY

Anthropic: mainly a pricing gap. OpenAI: safety is the stated reason; price unproven

*Status: Company = company statement or executive on the record; Filing = SEC filing; Media = press report citing unnamed people (*internal remarks, reported). Full sources on the Sources page.*

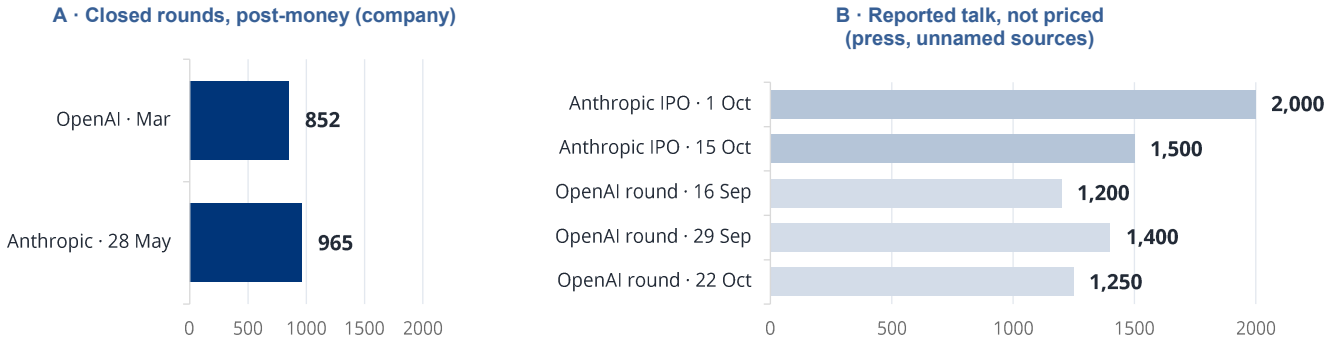
Facts and Figures

Insight Coverage | Issue No. 1

Closed rounds rose; reported price talk has since eased

Closed rounds valued Anthropic at $965bn and OpenAI at $852bn. Unpriced talk has eased from its peak, and US IPO proceeds outside each quarter's largest deal fell sharply in Q3.

EXHIBIT 1 · VALUATIONS, US$BN · A: CLOSED ROUNDS · B: REPORTED TALK · MAR–OCT 2026



Sources: A — company announcements (OpenAI, Mar 2026; Anthropic, 28 May 2026). B — Bloomberg (1 Oct, top of $1.8–2.0tn range shown; 29 Sep), Reuters (15 Oct), FT via Fortune (16 Sep), CNBC (22 Oct). B bars are reported asks from unnamed sources on differing bases, not prices: read the direction, not the gaps. Full sources on the Sources page.

Where from. Anthropic revenue: S-1 for 2025 ($4.6bn), Q1 ($4.7bn) and Q2 ($11.6bn); Q3 ($16.8bn) is company-stated at its 14 Oct investor day, via Reuters. OpenAI's figures are all press-reported; its last reported quarter is $6.7bn (Q2, WSJ).

Revenue quality (S-1). Revenue is "primarily consumption-based" and mostly not under long-term contracts: contracted backlog was $10.8bn at 30 Jun, below one quarter's revenue. Top five customers were ~25% of 9M revenue, and Anthropic estimates 5–7% came from customers breaching its terms, a share it expects to fall.

Cost to deliver. Compute and infrastructure (which also funds research) fell from 201% of revenue in H1 2025 to 55% in H1 2026; Q2 was the first operating profit ($1.0bn).

Market. Renaissance Capital (US IPOs ≥$50m market cap, ex-SPACs, closed-end funds, units), excluding each quarter's largest deal: Q1 33 deals, ~$8.4bn (ex-Forgent, $1.5bn); Q2 47 deals, $29.8bn (ex-SpaceX, $75bn); Q3 29 deals, $6.2bn (ex-SK hynix, $26.5bn).

Pricing. In Q3, 30% of IPOs priced below range and 39% fell on day one; Renaissance names three postponements (Oura, Bamboo, Amaero). Thin and price-sensitive, not shut.

Club calculation. $16.8bn × 4 = $67.2bn annualised: $1.5tn ≈ 22x, $2.0tn ≈ 30x. The shortcut ignores that revenue is usage-based, compute still costs about half of it, and ~$530bn of commitments to 2045 must be funded. The multiple is a bet that fast growth lasts.

KEY FIGURES

+45%
Anthropic revenue, Q3 vs Q2 (company, via Reuters)
vs +147% in Q2 (S-1; Club calc.)

−25%
Anthropic IPO talk, 1–15 Oct
~$2.0tn→ ~$1.5tn (press reports; Club calc.)

~$530bn
Anthropic compute commitments signed
$265.6bn on 30 Jun + ~$266bn since (S-1; Club sum)

$6.2bn
Q3 US IPO proceeds excl. SK hynix (29 deals)
vs $29.8bn in Q2 excl. SpaceX (47 deals)

EXHIBIT 2 · EVENT WINDOW: RATES AND CREDIT RISK

DATE	EVENT	10-YR UST	HY OAS
11 Jun	SpaceX prices at $135	4.45%	2.78%
16 Sep	Fed hikes 25bp to 3.75–4.00%	5.01%	2.70%
5 Oct	10-yr peak for Sep–Oct	5.31%	3.12%
15 Oct	Anthropic talk ~$1.5tn (Reuters)	5.10%	3.23%
22 Oct	OpenAI round $1.25tn (CNBC)	4.96%	3.40%
28 Oct	Fed holds; information cutoff	5.05%	3.14%

Exhibit 2: FRED DGS10 and ICE BofA US High Yield OAS (BAMLH0A0HYM2), daily values retrieved 3 Nov 2026 (FRED may revise). An event-window comparison: it shows what moved around each date, not what caused the decisions. HY spreads proxy risk appetite, not the issuers cost of equity.

Our Analysis

Insight Coverage | Issue No. 1

Are the AI IPOs slipping because of price or a closed market?

Higher rates raised the bar, but the October cuts in valuation talk came while yields were below their September high. The evidence fits a pricing gap that rates and AI risk aversion have widened.

Rates raised the bar. The Fed raised rates by 25bp on 16 Sep to 3.75–4.00%, its first hike since 2023, and the 10-year closed at 5.18% on 24 Sep (FRED). Higher Treasury yields can lower equity valuations by raising discount rates, although risk premia, growth expectations and company-specific risks also matter (Exhibit 3). Renaissance links Q3's weak finish to 19-year-high yields, resumed hikes and AI-spending worries.

But the timing does not fit rates as the main cause. OpenAI's lean toward 2027 was reported on 25 Jun, three months before the yield spike, citing SpaceX's volatility and Sam Altman's $1tn goal (NYT). Anthropic's 25% cut in reported talk came on 15 Oct, when the 10-year was below its late-September high. Meanwhile, high-yield spreads widened ~60bp (Exhibit 2), suggesting weaker market risk appetite rather than directly explaining the reported valuation changes.

Operating performance: Anthropic's QoQ growth slowed from +147% to +45%, while OpenAI's operating loss widened from $9.3bn (Q1, The Information) to $12.3bn (Q2, WSJ). **Financing needs:** OpenAI burned $3.7bn in Q1, while Anthropic's $42.0bn 2025 net loss was largely non-cash, including $34.3bn in fair-value changes on convertible notes and SAFES against an $8.1bn operating loss (S-1). **Governance and safety:** AI oversight, regulatory exposure and safety commitments introduce further uncertainty for investors.

Our view. A pricing gap: private money lets both wait, while higher yields and wider spreads have lowered what public buyers will pay. Confidence is moderate. We would change it if Anthropic priced at or above ~$2tn, as strong public demand would weaken the pricing-gap thesis, though not rule out an earlier gap.

THE TEST

1 THE CLAIM

Higher yields cut the value of distant profits, so the biggest, least profitable IPOs wait.

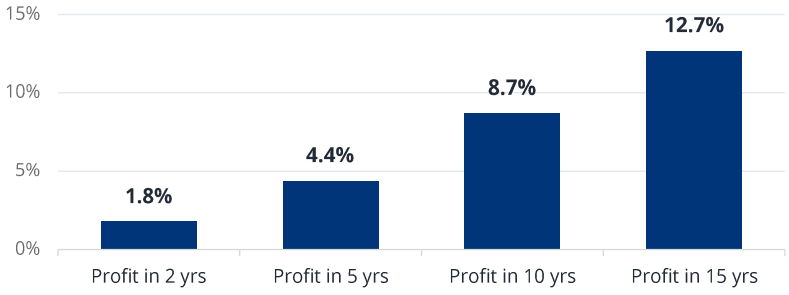
2 WHAT FITS

Fed hike (16 Sep); 10-yr 5.18% (24 Sep); HY spreads 2.80% → 3.40% (24 Sep–22 Oct); 30% of Q3 IPOs priced below range.

3 WHERE IT BREAKS

OpenAI's lean to 2027 predates the spike; Anthropic's cut came as yields eased; and Anthropic is near operating break-even (H1 loss $0.7bn), so it is less exposed than the claim assumes.

EXHIBIT 3 · ILLUSTRATION: % OF VALUE LOST WHEN THE DISCOUNT RATE GOES FROM 10% TO 11%



Club calculation. Present value of $1 in year t = 1/(1+r)^t. Fall = 1 − (1.10/1.11)^t. The 10% to 11% discount rate change and single future cash flow are hypothetical, not observed Treasury yield movements or a valuation of either company.

For context. A 25% fall in the value of a single year-15 cash flow would require a ~2.1 percentage-point rise in the assumed discount rate. This is illustrative, not an explanation of Anthropic's valuation change, which also depends on cash flows, growth and risk premia.

Source: Club calculation; rate data FRED DGS10. Bars rounded to one decimal.

> *"Rates set the hurdle; pricing gaps may influence timing, alongside funding and governance."*

ANOTHER WAY TO READ IT

Same market, different choices: Anthropic filed publicly on 26 Oct while OpenAI closes a private round. Company-specific factors matter but Anthropic's final IPO pricing and post-listing performance will better test public investor appetite.

RISKS TO WATCH

Oura illustrates the pricing gap: its planned $2.2bn IPO was ~4x oversubscribed but postponed on 29 Sep, amid investor concerns over its >$15bn valuation (Bloomberg). Indicated demand did not guarantee acceptance of the proposed price.

Full sources on the Sources page.

What's Next

Insight Coverage | Issue No. 1

What would close the pricing gap for the biggest AI listings?

Scope: very large AI listings, not all US IPOs. Anthropic's November pricing is the first real test; below are the signals, starting levels and review dates that would confirm or overturn our view.

ON OUR RADAR

1

Anthropic's offer price vs reported talk

Source: amended S-1 and pricing release · Start: $1.5–2.0tn talk (WSJ, 26 Oct) · Review: price-range filing and pricing

What changes our opinion: Priced at or above ~$2tn with strong post-IPO trading → pricing gap less likely. Range cut or delay→ pricing gap more likely, subject to investor demand, market conditions and company-specific factors

2

High-yield credit spread

Source: FRED BAMLH0A0HYM2 · Start: 3.14% on 28 Oct (2.80% on 24 Sep) · Review: 9 Dec, after the Fed

What changes our opinion: Below ~2.8% (September baseline) → improving risk appetite, potentially supporting IPO demand. Further widening→ weaker risk appetite, potentially widening the pricing gap and favouring private funding.

3

10-year Treasury yield

Source: FRED DGS10 · Start: 4.99% on 27 Oct (5.18% on 24 Sep) · Review: 9 Dec, after the Fed

What changes our opinion: If Anthropic prices well while the 10-year sits above its September high, this weakens the rates-only explanation, but broader IPO pricing and demand must be checked before drawing market-wide conclusions.

Confirmed vs expected. On 28 Oct the Fed held at 3.75–4.00%; Governor Cook and Cleveland Fed President Hammack dissented in favour of a 25bp hike (Fed statement, 28 October). Markets anticipated a possible December hike, but this remained an expectation, not a decision.

Filing status. Anthropic's public S-1 (26 Oct; ticker ANT, Nasdaq) leaves price range, share count and date blank; WSJ reports a target of the week of 16 Nov. Filing is progress, not a priced IPO. OpenAI has said 2027 "or sooner", with no date.

What would prove us wrong.

(1) Anthropic prices at or above ~$2tn without cutting its range.

(2) OpenAI lists in H1 2027 (hypothetical) at or above its last private mark while HY spreads remaining above 3%.

(3) Anthropic delays again despite narrowing spreads and falling yields fall, pointing to company issues, not price. We would assess these alongside broader IPO demand, aftermarket performance and pricing concessions.

Next issue:

Anthropic's offer price vs the $1.5–2.0tn talk, any range cut, book quality (oversubscription, long-only share), day-one and 30-day trading (publicly verifiable), and concessions such as a smaller float or lock-up changes (where reported), with SpaceX's slide below its offer price as the benchmark.

KEY TAKEAWAY

A pricing gap that rates widen, not a closed window

OPEN QUESTIONS

Will Anthropic price inside the talk?

Do spreads narrow by December?

Can OpenAI fund 2027 privately?

UPCOMING MILESTONE:

28 Oct	Wk of 16 Nov	8–9 Dec	2027
Fed held at 3.75–4.00%	Anthropic target listing	FOMC meeting (hike priced)	OpenAI IPO
Confirmed · Fed	*Reported · WSJ*	*Confirmed · Fed calendar*	*Company intent · no date*

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The Research Department analyses landmark M&A transactions, from strategic rationale and valuation to deal structure, legal considerations and post-deal performance.

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Publication Details

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Research Department

Prepared by António Pólvora and Aoife Palmer-Oriordan, under the guidance of Alberto Gonçalves. Examines the role of pricing, market conditions and company-specific factors in IPO timing.

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Sources and Method

Sources

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Method

- Sample: Renaissance Capital US IPOs and direct listings ≥$50m market cap, excluding SPACs, closed-end funds and unit offerings. "Excluding the largest deal" removes each quarter's biggest IPO (Q1 Forgent, Q2 SpaceX, Q3 SK hynix). Postponement: IPO delayed after insufficient investor demand; withdrawal: formal withdrawal of the registration (SEC Form RW), per Renaissance Capital's IPO Glossary.
- All values in US$; no currency conversions. Closed rounds are post-money. OpenAI talk is pre-money where the source says so (Bloomberg, CNBC); the FT basis is not stated. Anthropic talk is an IPO valuation. OpenAI "cash burn" is a company projection as reported (net cash consumed; unaudited, driven largely by compute), so treat it as indicative.
- Club calculations: growth Q2 = 11.6/4.7 − 1 = 147%, Q3 = 16.8/11.6 − 1 = 45%; annualised Q3 = 16.8 × 4; multiple = valuation ÷ annualised revenue; commitments ≈ 265.6 + 245 + 21 ≈ $530bn (gross, some conditional, some since paid); Q1 ex-Forgent = 9.9 − 1.5; Q2 ex-SpaceX = 104.8 − 75.0; Exhibit 3 fall = 1 − (1.10/1.11)^t; rate rise for a 25% fall at t = 15: 1.10/0.75^(1/15) − 1.10 ≈ 2.1 pts.
- Every FRED value (Exhibit 2 and the radar items) is the daily observation retrieved on 3 Nov 2026; FRED may revise history. No secondary snapshots are used.

Information cutoff: 28 October 2026. Every source carries its own publication date; the issue cutoff is kept separate from event and observation dates.

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